

SHORELINES · MORNING EDITION

Morning Edition

Thursday, 20 August 2026

JUMP TO STORY

01 · Seabed 2030: 28.7% mapped, sprint open

02 ·



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S T O R Y 0 1

Seabed 2030 has now mapped 28.7% of the ocean floor, and the next data sprint is taking registrations

Registration for the Indo-Pacific Data Sprint in Kuala Lumpur this October is open now, and it is the exact room where a Seychelles bathymetry dataset gets checked against GEBCO standards and folded into the public grid instead of sitting on a hard drive.

STORY NOTES

The Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project has mapped 28.7% of the world's ocean floor, with almost

five million square kilometres added in the past year alone. Mitsuyuki Unno, the Nippon Foundation's Executive Director, announced the figure at the International Hydrographic Organization Assembly in Monaco. The GEBCO_2026 grid, the compiled public dataset the whole project feeds into, is now released and downloadable.

The next concrete opportunity to contribute sits on the calendar. The Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint runs 20 to 22 October in Kuala Lumpur, and registration is open now. Data sprints are the mechanism by which crowdsourced and national bathymetry gets validated against GEBCO's quality standards and merged into the grid, rather than staying siloed in a national agency's archive.

Register or find submission guidance at seabed2030.org.

STORY ARTICLE

Four years out from the project's 2030 deadline, 28.7% mapped means 71.3% of the ocean floor still has no direct depth measurement at all, only satellite-derived estimates with a fraction of the resolution. Five million square kilometres added this year is real progress, roughly the

size of the European Union added in twelve months. But the pace needed to close the remaining gap by 2030 is still steep, and most of what remains unmapped sits precisely where survey vessels are scarcest: the Southern Ocean, the deep Pacific, and the waters around small island states that cannot fund their own hydrographic fleets.

That last category is the one that matters to you directly. An unmapped seafloor is not an abstract gap. It is a coastline you cannot model for tsunami run-up with confidence, an extended continental shelf claim you cannot fully substantiate, a submarine cable route chosen blind, a marine protected area boundary drawn on satellite-derived bathymetry that might be off by tens of metres in depth. Seychelles' own EEZ, at close to 1.4 million square kilometres against a landmass of 455, is a case study in how much ocean a small state is expected to govern with survey capacity it does not have.

This is the gap HARMONiSE and the Ocean Mapping Hub exist to narrow, and the Kuala Lumpur sprint is a working example of the mechanism rather than a one-off event. Regional data sprints bring together hydrographic offices, universities, and community mapping groups to pool whatever bathymetry they have collected, whether from

research cruises, fishing vessel echo sounders, or satellite-derived bathymetry pipelines, and run it through GEBCO's validation process together, in the room, over three days.

The standard objection to crowdsourced bathymetry is worth naming rather than waving off: data collected by non-specialist vessels varies wildly in accuracy, metadata is often incomplete, and folding low-confidence soundings into a global grid risks degrading trust in the whole dataset. Seabed 2030 answers this with a tiered validation pipeline. Crowdsourced data goes through automated and manual quality checks before merging, and contributors get feedback on what passed and what didn't, which is itself useful capacity-building for a fledgling observatory learning to meet international hydrographic standards.

The Indo-Pacific sprint is also a geography argument. Most Seabed 2030 regional centres and prior data sprints have clustered around larger maritime states with established hydrographic offices. A Kuala Lumpur sprint pulling in the wider Indo-Pacific, rather than routing everything through a single global centre, is the kind of regional infrastructure that a Western Indian Ocean equivalent could eventually be modelled on, or that

SHORE could seek a seat at directly given the overlapping ocean basin.

The practical move is straightforward: register for the sprint now, and start assembling whatever bathymetric data SHORE or its partners already hold, however partial, so it has somewhere validated to go in October rather than sitting unprocessed for another year.

Register and read the data submission standards:

seabed2030.org

Seychelles just signed its single largest GEF project, USD 10.48 million for the blue and green economy

UNDP and Seychelles's Ministry of Environment have signed the largest GEF project Seychelles has ever secured, and USD 10.48 million routed through your own government's blue economy priorities is the kind of domestic funding architecture SHORE should be positioning itself inside, not watching from outside.

STORY NOTES

UNDP and Seychelles's Ministry of Environment signed a GEF-8 project worth USD 10.48 million in January this

year, described as the single largest GEF project Seychelles has secured to date. The project is aimed at scaling up efforts to safeguard Seychelles's natural heritage while advancing sustainable and inclusive economic development across the blue and green economy.

The signing sits alongside Seychelles's existing GEF-8 country programming and builds on years of GEF-backed environmental and marine work in the country, including prior support for marine spatial planning and protected area expansion.

Details of the project's full results framework were not part of the announcement itself; the practical next step is finding UNDP Mauritius-Seychelles's project document to see where the implementation windows and partnership entry points sit.

STORY ARTICLE

USD 10.48 million is a modest figure by the standards of global climate finance, and that is precisely the point worth sitting with. It being described as Seychelles's largest-ever single GEF project tells you as much about the ceiling small island states hit in multilateral

environmental finance as it does about the project itself. Seychelles is a high-income country by World Bank classification, which routes it away from concessional finance, and yet its largest environmental grant to date is a rounding error against the scale of the coastal and marine management challenge a 1.4 million square kilometre EEZ actually represents.

That contradiction is the High-Income SIDS Paradox in a single funding line: a country judged too wealthy for concessional climate finance, expected to self-fund ocean governance at a scale few high-income states of comparable population attempt, financing its largest domestic environmental project with a grant that would be considered mid-sized in most other multilateral contexts.

What the project does with the money matters more than the headline number. GEF-8 blue and green economy framing typically spans protected area management, sustainable fisheries transitions, and natural capital accounting, the kind of work that depends on exactly the spatial data infrastructure SHORE is building toward. A national-scale grant of this size, running through the Ministry of Environment rather than through an external research partner, is a live test of whether Seychelles's own government has the technical capacity to execute

blue economy commitments without importing expertise wholesale from outside the country.

That is where the opening sits. A domestically signed, domestically implemented project of this scale needs technical partners who understand both the spatial science and the Seychelles institutional context, which is a narrower field than it should be. SHORE's positioning as a Seychelles-based hydrospatial research institute, rather than a foreign consultancy parachuting in for a contract, is a genuine comparative advantage here, but only if the relevant ministry actually knows SHORE exists and has capacity to contribute before implementation architecture is locked in.

The honest risk is timing. GEF project signings often precede a slow ramp into actual implementation contracts, sometimes by a year or more, while inception phases, procurement processes, and technical working groups get established. Waiting for a formal call for partners risks missing the window where the project's technical scope is still being defined rather than already fixed. The better move is proactive: request the project document from UNDP Mauritius-Seychelles directly and find out which implementing unit is standing up the technical side now.

UNDP announcement: undp.org/mauritius-seychelles

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator reopens for proposals this year, and Seychelles has won before

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator's next call opens this year, grants of £5,000 to £50,000 for exactly the kind of government-NGO ocean policy partnership SHORE and Seychelles's government could build together, and Seychelles has already been one of eight countries funded in a prior round.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator's next call for proposals is set to open this year, following a first round that closed in 2023. The Incubator funds catalytic

grants of £5,000 to £50,000 to Commonwealth governments for government-NGO or government-private sector partnerships, covering training, capacity-building, knowledge exchange, and rapid climate risk or vulnerability assessments tied to ocean policy.

Eight projects were funded from the first round, including one from Seychelles, alongside Barbados, Canada, Fiji, Kiribati, Nigeria, and two from Sri Lanka. That track record makes a second Seychelles submission a credible, not speculative, proposition.

Enquiries go to bluecharter@commonwealth.int; watch thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter for the exact call date.

STORY ARTICLE

Small grants get underrated in a funding landscape dominated by nine and ten figure climate finance headlines, and that is a mistake worth correcting here. A £5,000 to £50,000 catalytic grant is exactly the right size for the stage SHORE is actually at: not a multi-year infrastructure build, but a defined piece of capacity-building, a training programme, a rapid vulnerability assessment, or a knowledge exchange that produces

something concrete enough to cite in the next, larger funding application.

The structural design of the Incubator is worth understanding before drafting anything. It funds government-NGO or government-private sector partnerships specifically, not NGOs applying alone. That means a competitive SHORE proposal needs a named government co-applicant from the outset, most plausibly Seychelles's Ministry of Environment or the Blue Economy department successor, not a partnership assembled after the call opens. Given the GEF-8 signing covered in story 02, that same ministry is already visibly active in blue economy programming this year, which makes now a reasonable moment to open that conversation rather than waiting for the call text to land.

Seychelles's prior success in the first Incubator round is the strongest asset in this pitch and the easiest one to overlook. A government that has already delivered on a Blue Charter Incubator grant is a lower-risk applicant than one applying cold, and Commonwealth Secretariat programme officers remember delivery track records. Finding out which Seychellois institution held that first grant, what it funded, and how it was reported on is worth

an afternoon before the new call opens, both to learn from it and to potentially build directly on it.

The honest limitation of a grant this size needs stating plainly: £50,000 will not fund a data infrastructure build, a mapping campaign, or anything resembling HARMONiSE's core technical work. What it can fund is the scaffolding around that work: a training programme that builds Seychellois technical capacity to eventually run HARMONiSE-style processes independently, or a rapid assessment that generates the evidence base a larger funder will later want to see cited. Positioning it that way, as the first rung rather than the whole ladder, is what makes the proposal credible rather than mismatched to its budget.

The Commonwealth's own Blue Charter Champion structure, where individual member states lead thematic action groups, is also worth checking for openings; if Seychelles or a peer SIDS chairs a relevant action group, that is a faster route to visibility than a cold proposal.

Programme page and contact:

thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter

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$ seabed2030 --status federated-marine-data-infra
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S T O R Y 0 4

The OGC is building a federated data spine for ocean spatial information, and it's the interoperability layer HARMONiSE will have to sit on

The Open Geospatial Consortium's Marine Domain Working Group is building the federated data infrastructure that ocean spatial datasets will eventually have to plug into, and HARMONiSE not being built to that standard now is a compatibility problem waiting to surface later.

S T O R Y N O T E S

The OGC's Marine Domain Working Group is developing a Federated Marine Spatial Data Infrastructure, an interoperability layer meant to let ocean datasets held by different national agencies, research bodies, and companies work together without everyone first migrating onto the same platform.

GeoAI applications built on top of this kind of infrastructure are already operational elsewhere: deep learning models segmenting underwater imagery for coral reef and habitat mapping, satellite-based vessel detection for illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing, and AI-driven image classification for coastline and seafloor mapping.

The working group operates through the standard OGC public process; its specifications and working drafts are published for review as they develop.

STORY ARTICLE

Marine spatial planning has a data problem that predates any argument about artificial intelligence: the datasets it

depends on, bathymetry, habitat maps, vessel traffic, fisheries effort, environmental sensor data, are collected by different agencies, in different formats, on different schedules, and mostly do not talk to each other. A planner trying to build a defensible MSP zone has to manually reconcile half a dozen incompatible sources before the actual analysis starts. That reconciliation cost is invisible in most funding proposals and enormous in practice.

The OGC's Federated Marine Spatial Data Infrastructure work is aimed directly at that problem, not by forcing every agency onto one platform, which has failed repeatedly across two decades of geospatial data-sharing initiatives, but by defining the interoperability standards that let separately-hosted datasets be queried and combined as if they were one. If it succeeds, or even partially succeeds, it becomes the plumbing everyone's marine spatial data eventually has to speak to.

This matters for HARMONiSE specifically, not abstractly. A hydrospatial framework built in isolation, on its own schema, its own coordinate handling, its own metadata conventions, gets harder to connect to this kind of federated infrastructure the longer it develops independently. Building toward OGC standards now, even in a small state with limited engineering capacity, is

considerably cheaper than retrofitting compliance after HARMONiSE's data model is already locked into partner systems and published outputs.

The GeoAI applications already running on comparable infrastructure elsewhere give a concrete sense of what interoperability actually buys. Vessel detection for illegal fishing depends on combining satellite imagery, AIS tracking data, and known fishing ground boundaries from separate sources in near real time; none of that works if the underlying datasets cannot be queried together. Coral reef mapping through deep learning segmentation similarly depends on standardised underwater imagery metadata across contributing surveys, or the training data itself becomes unusable across institutions.

The honest caveat is that OGC working group output moves slowly and its adoption is uneven; plenty of national ocean data infrastructure still runs on bespoke, non-interoperable systems a decade after comparable standards existed. Betting HARMONiSE's architecture entirely on a working group's draft standard carries its own risk if that standard stalls or fragments. The more defensible position is tracking the working group's outputs closely enough to align where it is stable, without treating an unfinished specification as a fixed target.

The practical step is getting SHORE, or a technical lead within it, onto the OGC Marine Domain Working Group's public mailing list or review process, so alignment happens by design during development rather than as an expensive retrofit later.

Who owns Pacific ocean knowledge is now a live governance question, not a footnote to it

Indigenous data sovereignty frameworks emerging across the Pacific are the governance vocabulary that data sovereignty work at SHORE needs to be fluent in, because the argument Seychelles will eventually have to make about who controls its own ocean data is the same one Pacific communities are already making about theirs.

STORY NOTES

Indigenous data sovereignty, the principle that Indigenous peoples should govern how data about their own land, waters, and knowledge is collected, accessed, stored,

and used, is receiving expanded treatment in this year's Indigenous World report from the International Work Group for Indigenous Affairs, and is the organising focus of the Pacific Data Sovereignty Network's ongoing work.

Traditional ocean knowledge, navigation, environmental observation, and food systems built over generations, is increasingly documented through formal research programmes; one researcher within the Norway-Pacific Ocean-Climate Programme, of Indian and Banaban-Gilbertese descent, is currently studying how displacement has affected Banaban communities' traditional ocean knowledge specifically.

These frameworks distinguish sharply between documenting knowledge and controlling it, a distinction that matters wherever external researchers or institutions are the ones doing the recording.

STORY ARTICLE

Data sovereignty gets discussed most often at the state level, who controls a country's EEZ data, whose servers host a national bathymetric survey, which foreign research vessel gets clearance to collect what. The Indigenous data sovereignty framework

operating across the Pacific right now asks a related but distinct question: even within a state's own borders, who controls data about a specific community's knowledge and territory, and does that community have a say in how it gets used once collected.

The Banaban case is worth sitting with directly. Banaban communities were displaced from Ocean Island, now Banaba in Kiribati, in the twentieth century, largely for phosphate mining, and now live dispersed across Fiji, Kiribati, and elsewhere. A researcher documenting their traditional ocean knowledge is working against active displacement, not just cultural distance, which raises the sovereignty question sharply: knowledge generated by a community no longer living on its ancestral waters, recorded by an external research programme, raises real questions about who ultimately controls how it circulates.

This connects to SHORE's own data sovereignty work more directly than it might first appear. Seychelles is not an Indigenous-rights case in the same sense, but the underlying structural question is close to identical: hydrospatial and environmental data generated in and about a small state routinely ends up hosted, processed, and made most accessible on infrastructure outside that state's own jurisdiction, whether through international

research partnerships, satellite data agreements, or multilateral programme reporting requirements. The Pacific's Indigenous data sovereignty vocabulary gives that same structural problem, applied to Seychelles at the national scale, a sharper and more established framework to argue from.

The distinction between documenting and controlling knowledge is the useful analytical tool here, and it applies beyond the Indigenous rights context specifically. A dataset that exists is not the same as a dataset a community, or a country, actually governs. Hosting location, licensing terms, citation requirements, and veto rights over downstream use are the mechanics that separate the two, and they are exactly the mechanics that tend to get skipped in the rush to sign a data-sharing agreement with a well-resourced international partner.

Worth naming the tension honestly: sovereignty-first data governance can slow down research and funding relationships that move faster when data flows freely to whichever partner asks first. The Pacific frameworks treat that friction as a feature, not a bug, on the argument that speed without control has historically cost communities and small states more than it has benefited them. That is the same trade-off SHORE will eventually have to make

explicit in its own partnership agreements, and having a citable regional precedent for choosing control over speed is worth having on hand before that negotiation happens.

Sources: IWGIA, The Indigenous World 2026 · Pacific Data
Sovereignty Network

S T O R Y 0 6

+500

zettajoules of ocean heat content added since the 1940s,
WMO State of the Global Climate 2025

The ocean has absorbed 500 zettajoules of extra heat since the 1940s, and 2025 set a fresh record on top of it

The WMO's 2025 climate report puts a hard number on a trend Shorelines has been writing around for years, and 500 zettajoules of accumulated ocean heat is the kind of anchor figure that turns your governance argument from a general claim into an evidenced one.

STORY NOTES

The World Meteorological Organization's 36th annual State of the Global Climate report, released this month, confirms that greenhouse gas concentrations, global sea level, and ocean heat content all reached record highs in 2025. More than 90% of the planet's excess heat from warming is stored in the ocean, and ocean heat content between the surface and 2,000 metres has risen by around 500 zettajoules, billion trillion joules, since the 1940s.

Sea level rise is now accelerating at 4.7 millimetres a year. 2025 ranks as the second or third hottest year on record at roughly 1.43°C above the 1850 to 1900 baseline, and 2015 to 2025 are collectively the eleven hottest years ever recorded.

Full report: wmo.int

STORY ARTICLE

Five hundred zettajoules is not a number most people can picture, so it is worth converting it into something closer to felt experience: it is the ocean acting as the planet's near-total heat sink, absorbing over 90% of the excess energy trapped by rising greenhouse gas concentrations since industrialisation accelerated, and doing so quietly

enough that the number rarely makes a headline the way a single heatwave or hurricane does. The WMO's 2025 figure is not a new phenomenon. It is the same accumulation continuing on the same trajectory, now with 2025 added as the latest record year on top of it.

The sea level figure is the one with the sharpest practical bite for Seychelles specifically. Acceleration to 4.7 millimetres a year does not sound dramatic against a single year's tide chart, but sea level acceleration compounds, and coastal infrastructure, port design, MSP boundary assumptions, and property risk models built on older, slower rise projections are already running behind the physical reality. A national conversation about coastal adaptation anchored on outdated rise assumptions is a national conversation planning for the wrong ocean.

The ocean heat figure matters for a second, less obvious reason: it is directly upstream of coral bleaching, fisheries productivity shifts, and marine heatwave frequency, all of which sit inside SHORE's remit and Shorelines' subject matter regularly. Citing "the ocean is warming" without the WMO's number behind it is a general claim easily waved off in a room full of sceptical funders or officials. Citing 500 zettajoules since the 1940s, sourced to the WMO's flagship annual report, is not.

The honest complication is that a report like this one gets cited constantly and specifically almost never, which dilutes its usefulness the moment it turns into another generic "the ocean is warming" line. The number only does the work it is capable of doing if it shows up attached to a specific, local argument: this is why Seychelles's coastal infrastructure standards from a decade ago are undersized, this is why an MSP zone drawn on 2015 sea level assumptions needs revisiting, this is why a funding proposal's climate risk section needs a harder number than "increasing temperatures."

The practical use is straightforward. Pull the specific 500 zettajoule and 4.7 millimetre figures directly into the next Shorelines piece or funding narrative that touches ocean warming or sea level, cited to WMO 2026, rather than reaching for a softer, unsourced framing. Anchoring claims in numbers like this is exactly the gap that tends to lose a room; this report closes it.

Report and methodology: [wmo.int](https://www.wmo.int)

Funders are still treating SIDS as too risky to finance, even as the climate bill for waiting keeps rising

A fresh finance-sector analysis confirms what your High-Income SIDS Paradox argument has been saying for years, that funders label small island states too small and too risky to finance at exactly the moment those states need capital fastest, and that is a citable data point, not just a lived frustration.

"Small Island Developing States are being systematically shut out of global climate finance despite facing some of the most acute climate

impacts, with funders viewing these nations as too small, fragmented, and risky to support."

STORY NOTES

New reporting from Carbon Pulse and UNCTAD confirms that SIDS access to climate finance remains disproportionately low relative to their climate exposure, with funders citing scale, fragmentation, and perceived risk as barriers, the same structural complaint SIDS negotiators have raised for over a decade without material change to the finance architecture behind it.

The contrast sits directly against the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration, adopted by all 56 Commonwealth member states as one of the largest marine protection agreements to date, and the ORCA initiative, which aims to deliver more than USD 300 million in grants over four years across ocean-climate priorities. Declared ambition and deliverable finance remain two different things.

UNCTAD analysis: unctad.org

STORY ARTICLE

"Too small, fragmented, and risky" is worth reading as a technical finance judgement rather than a throwaway characterisation, because it is precisely that: a risk-adjusted return calculation that treats small transaction size, thin institutional capacity, and limited co-financing partners as cost, not context. A USD 5 million adaptation project in Seychelles carries roughly the same due diligence overhead as a USD 50 million project elsewhere, and from a pure portfolio-management view, that math discourages exactly the finance SIDS need most.

This is the High-Income SIDS Paradox from the finance side rather than the classification side. Seychelles sits above the income threshold that would route it toward concessional climate finance, and it is simultaneously judged too small and fragmented for the commercial and blended finance instruments that are supposed to fill that gap. The result is a country caught in the space between two financing tracks, neither of which was designed with a population of under 100,000 spread across 115 islands in mind.

The Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration and the ORCA initiative's USD 300 million commitment are worth citing, but worth citing carefully. Declarations signed by 56 member states and grant programmes announced at

four-year scale are exactly the kind of pledge that the Mombasa Our Ocean Conference commitments, and frankly most climate finance announcements of the last decade, have taught observers to treat with structured scepticism: announced capital and disbursed capital are not the same figure, and the gap between them has a well-documented history of running large.

The counter-argument from the finance side deserves a fair hearing rather than dismissal. Small, fragmented transaction sizes genuinely do carry higher administrative cost per dollar deployed, and funders operating with fiduciary obligations to their own backers cannot simply absorb that cost as a matter of goodwill. The fair response to that argument is not to deny the cost exists, but to point out that blended finance vehicles, regional pooling mechanisms, and SIDS-specific facilities exist precisely to solve this problem, and remain chronically underfunded relative to the scale of stranded small-state demand they were built to absorb.

The practical use of this story is as citable evidence, not just validation. The next time SHORE or Shorelines makes the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument to a funder, a peer, or a conference room, the UNCTAD and Carbon Pulse reporting gives it a named, dated, external source

rather than leaving it as an argument that sounds like special pleading from inside the affected group. That distinction matters more than it should, and it is worth using deliberately.

Reporting: carbon-pulse.com · unctad.org

BBNJ's Preparatory Commission wrapped up in April with the hard governance questions still open, and COP1 is five months away

The gaps PrepCom3 left unresolved, subsidiary body delays and unfinished rules on marine protected area establishment, are exactly the mechanics that decide whether BBNJ becomes usable ocean governance for Seychelles or stays a treaty that entered into force without the machinery to run it.

STORY NOTES

The third and final Preparatory Commission session before BBNJ's first Conference of the Parties concluded

on 2 April at UN Headquarters in New York, the first PrepCom meeting following the Agreement's entry into force on 17 January 2026, at which point it had 83 parties and 145 signatories.

PrepCom3 identified that the treaty's subsidiary bodies will not be fully established by COP1, risking up to a year's delay in implementation across the Agreement. Draft text on the relationship between BBNJ bodies and other organisations risks creating barriers or delays specifically around marine protected area establishment, and the rules governing BBNJ's interaction with Regional Fisheries Management Organisations remain undecided, deferred to COP1 itself.

COP1 is scheduled for January 2027, one year after entry into force, as required under the Agreement's own terms.

STORY ARTICLE

A treaty entering into force is the headline moment; a treaty actually functioning is a much slower and less photogenic process, and BBNJ is squarely in that second phase now. PrepCom3's conclusion in April did the necessary preparatory work of surfacing where the Agreement's machinery is still unbuilt, but surfacing a gap

is not the same as closing it, and several of the gaps identified go directly to whether BBNJ can do the thing it was negotiated to do.

The subsidiary bodies delay is the most structurally significant of the three. BBNJ's implementation depends on functioning scientific, technical, and financial subsidiary bodies to actually process marine protected area proposals, environmental impact assessment standards, and benefit-sharing mechanisms for marine genetic resources. If those bodies are not fully stood up at COP1 in January 2027, the Agreement risks a full year where its core institutional plumbing is still being assembled rather than doing the work it exists to do. For a small state with limited capacity to run parallel tracks of engagement, a year of institutional delay is a year where BBNJ participation costs staff time without yet producing usable governance outcomes.

The marine protected area text is the second concern, and it cuts closest to Seychelles's direct interest. Seychelles has built its international ocean governance reputation substantially on marine protected area work, from the 30% MPA commitment tied to the debt-for-nature blue bond onward. Draft BBNJ text that creates unnecessary barriers or dependencies between BBNJ's

high seas MPA process and other existing bodies is a direct risk to how quickly and cleanly high seas protections adjacent to Seychelles's own maritime interests can actually be established, regardless of how strong the underlying scientific case is.

The RFMO relationship being deferred entirely to COP1 is the most consequential unresolved item, because fisheries management is where BBNJ's ambition meets its hardest political resistance. The Agreement does not directly regulate fisheries, deliberately, to avoid overlapping with existing regional fisheries bodies, but the practical boundary between BBNJ conservation measures and RFMO fisheries management authority was never fully settled in the negotiating text. Leaving it to COP1 means it becomes one of the first Conference's most contested agenda items, decided by consensus among parties with directly competing interests, rather than a technical detail worked out quietly in a preparatory session.

None of this should be read as BBNJ failing. Multilateral environmental agreements routinely take years past entry into force to become operationally functional; UNCLOS itself took over a decade to build out its full institutional architecture after 1994. What it should be read as is a

signal that the treaty's usefulness to Seychelles specifically will be decided less by the text agreed in 2023 and more by how COP1's negotiations resolve these three open items in January 2027. That is roughly five months from today, which is enough runway to prepare a clear Seychellois or SIDS-bloc position on the MPA and RFMO questions specifically, rather than arriving at COP1 to react to whatever draft language other blocs bring.

A major ocean engineering journal just went fully gold open access, and the shift is bigger than one title

The Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science converting to fully gold open access is one data point in a wider shift that changes where you can publish Shorelines-adjacent research without a paywall between it and the policymakers you're writing for.

STORY NOTES

The Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science, published by Elsevier, transitioned to fully gold open access from 1 January this year, joining Elsevier's family of more than 890 fully open access journals. Authors submitting from 1 November last year onward are charged

an article publishing fee after peer review and acceptance, rather than readers or institutions paying for access afterward.

As of March this year, the Directory of Open Access Journals listed 265 entries under geology, geodesy, and geophysics, and the Directory of Open Access Books listed 210 titles under earth sciences, geography, and environment and planning. Established venues including Ocean Science, published by Copernicus on behalf of the European Geosciences Union, and Oceanography, published by The Oceanography Society, remain open access by design.

STORY ARTICLE

Open access publishing is usually discussed as a researcher-access issue, whether a scientist at a resource-poor institution can read the paper they need, and that framing is correct but incomplete for anyone doing science-to-policy work specifically. The more consequential audience for open access in ocean governance is not other researchers. It is the ministry official, the treaty negotiator, and the small-state delegation staffer who needs the underlying evidence behind a policy position and does not have institutional

journal access, does not have a university library login, and is not going to email an author to request a PDF mid-negotiation.

The Journal of Ocean Engineering and Science's shift to gold open access is one title, but it is representative of a broader publishing-industry move that has real implications for where Shorelines-adjacent or SHORE-produced research should target publication. A paywalled paper cited in a policy brief is a citation the reader cannot actually verify without institutional access; an open access paper is one they can pull up and check on the spot, in the room, during the negotiation.

The gold open access model comes with a cost that shifts rather than disappears, worth naming plainly: article publishing charges, often running into the low thousands of dollars, move the cost from the reader to the author or the author's institution. For an independent researcher or a small NGO like SHORE without a university's institutional open access agreement behind it, that fee can be a genuine barrier to publishing in these venues, not a solved problem. The DOAJ's 265 geoscience entries include plenty of no-fee open access options worth knowing about specifically for that reason, alongside the fee-charging commercial titles.

The practical implication for Shorelines and any SHORE-affiliated research output is to build a working list now, before a manuscript is ready, of open access venues in ocean and geoscience that either charge no fee or have waiver policies for authors from lower and lower-middle income institutions, and to check whether Seychelles-based or Commonwealth-affiliated authors qualify for any existing waiver programmes attached to titles like Ocean Science or Oceanography.

The wider trend, publishing infrastructure gradually shifting toward open models across ocean and earth science, is worth tracking over the medium term rather than treating any single journal's announcement as decisive. It changes, slowly, who gets to be part of the evidence base a policy argument can credibly point to, and a small state with a strong evidence base but weak institutional publishing budgets has a direct stake in which model wins.

Seychelles' blue bond is eight years old now, and the question worth asking is what it actually financed

Fresh reporting revisiting Seychelles's blue bond as it matures is a chance to check the gap between the model everyone still cites and what it has actually delivered on the ground, which is the honest audit Shorelines is better placed to run than most outlets covering it.

STORY NOTES

Recent reporting from IPS and allAfrica revisits Seychelles's sovereign blue bond, the world's first, under the framing "Turning Ocean Vision into Action," assessing how the instrument's original marine conservation and sustainable fisheries goals are translating into implementation eight years on from its 2018 launch.

Alongside the bond, the Seychelles Conservation and Climate Adaptation Trust, SeyCCAT, continues to competitively grant at least USD 750,000 a year to support stewardship of Seychelles's ocean resources, island life, and blue economy, funded in part through the debt-conversion structure the blue bond helped establish.

Coverage: ipsnews.net

STORY ARTICLE

The Seychelles blue bond has been cited in international ocean finance circles for nearly a decade now as proof of concept: a small island state converting a slice of its sovereign debt into ring-fenced marine conservation financing, backed by the World Bank and GEF, tied to concrete commitments including the 30% marine protected area target reached in 2020. It is one of the most referenced pieces of Seychelles's international ocean governance reputation, and it has been referenced so consistently, for so long, that it is worth periodically checking whether the citation still matches the reality on the ground.

That is what this round of reporting attempts, and the honest framing, "turning vision into action," concedes the

gap implicitly before the piece even opens: eight years after launch, the story is still being told as translation from ambition to delivery rather than as settled achievement. That is not necessarily a failure. Ocean governance instruments of this kind are built for decades, not years, and SeyCCAT's continuing annual grant cycle of at least USD 750,000 is a genuine, ongoing delivery mechanism, not a one-time announcement that quietly stopped.

What is worth interrogating directly, and what a Shorelines piece is better positioned to do than most international coverage repeating the same origin story, is where that USD 750,000 a year has actually gone over eight annual cycles, what proportion of Seychelles's marine research and community stewardship capacity now depends on SeyCCAT funding specifically, and whether the pipeline of fundable projects has kept pace with the money available, or whether the fund has struggled to find enough strong applicants in a country with Seychelles's population and institutional scale.

The counter-narrative worth naming honestly is that "world's first sovereign blue bond" has become such a durable branding asset for Seychelles internationally that it risks outliving genuine scrutiny of its delivery. A financing instrument that gets cited approvingly at every

ocean finance conference for eight years running accumulates a kind of reputational momentum that makes hard questions about its actual impact harder to ask without sounding like you are attacking Seychelles's own achievement rather than testing it.

That tension, between a model worth defending and a model worth auditing honestly, is exactly the territory a Shorelines piece should sit in. The practical next step is requesting SeyCCAT's grant history and disbursement records directly, comparing them against the blue bond's original conservation targets, and writing the piece that asks not whether the blue bond was a good idea in 2018, which is well established, but what eight years of it has concretely produced, which is a question the international coverage keeps gesturing at without answering.

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